had sent me my first professional writing payment 14V2 years before, and I would have loved to have met him, but he was away somewhere on that day. That is the closest I ever got to meeting him—but, sentiment aside, it was better to meet Bea.)

"Everest" represents the fastest sale I ever made. It was sold one hour after I had put the paper in the typewriter to begin. It was the first time I had ever sold a first draft.

Bea and I went out for dinner together, and I really exerted myself to impress her with my debonaire manner. (She wasn't going to find me one of Dick Hoover's deadly professors.) Indeed, so successful was I at being lively and witty and effervescent that the middle-aged waitress leaned toward me to whisper that she wished her son-in-law was as interesting as I was. Unfortunately, I was aiming at Bea Mahaffey, who remained relatively unmoved, perhaps because she had no son-in-law.

We went to the movies afterward and then I took her home. I can't honestly say I had anything wicked in mind, though I'd like to believe I was prepared for the worst. The worst proved to be, however, a shake of the hand and a friendly good-bye, and then she disappeared into her apartment house and I turned back to get the streetcar to my hotel.

The next day I took the train and was home on April 9. The roomette had lost the charm of novelty on the return voyage, and I found its supercompactness a little wearying.

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My casually confident visit to Universe was evidence enough that I had come light-years from the time I had first crept, pallid and frightened, into Campbell's office fourteen years before. I was now well

enough known so that I could walk into the office of any science-fiction editor, even one I had never met before, and expect to be treated as a celebrity.

It was not that I demanded or even wanted deference. I just wanted my eccentricities overlooked. I wanted to be able to come swirling in, talking as I came, making jokes, hugging all the young ladies— and not be thrown out.

Of course, there wasn't much room for me to spread myself at the offices of magazine editors. Those were small and cramped and often there wasn't even